pay. However, in imposing such service, the State is not permitted to make any discrimination on grounds only of religion, race, caste or class.

2. Prohibition of Employment of Children in Factories, etc.

Article 24 prohibits the employment of children below the age of 14 years in any factory, mine or other hazardous activities like construction work or railway. But it does not prohibit their employment in any harmless or innocent work.

The Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act, 1986, is the most important law in this direction. In addition, the Employment of Children Act, 1938; the Factories Act, 1948; the Mines Act, 1952; the Merchant Shipping Act, 1958; the Plantation Labour Act, 1951; the Motor Transport Workers Act, 1951; Apprentices Act, 1961; the Bidi and Cigar Workers Act, 1966; and other similar acts prohibit the employment of children below certain age.

In 1996, the Supreme Court directed the establishment of Child Labour Rehabilitation Welfare Fund in which the offending employer should deposit a fine of ₹20,000 for each child employed by him/her. It also issued directions for the improvement of education, health and nutrition of children.

The Commissions for Protection of Child Rights Act, 2005 was enacted to provide for the establishment of a National Commission and State Commissions for Protection of Child Rights and Children's Courts for providing speedy trial of offences against children or of violation of child rights.

In 2006, the government banned the employment of children as domestic servants or workers in business establishments like hotels, dhabas, restaurants, shops, factories, resorts, spas, tea-shops and so on. It warned that anyone employing children below 14 years of age would be liable for prosecution and penal action.

The Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2016, amended the Child Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act, 1986. It has renamed the Principal Act as the Child and Adolescent Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act, 1986.

RIGHT TO FREEDOM OF RELIGION

1. Freedom of Conscience and Free Profession, Practice and Propagation of Religion

Article 25 says that all persons are equally entitled to freedom of conscience and the right to freely profess, practice and propagate religion. The implications of these are:

1. *Freedom of conscience:* Inner freedom of an individual to mould his/her relation with God or Creatures in whatever way he/she desires.

2. *Right to profess:* Declaration of one's religious beliefs and faith openly and freely.

3. *Right to practice:* Performance of religious worship, rituals, ceremonies and exhibition of beliefs and ideas.

4. *Right to propagate:* Transmission and dissemination of one's religious beliefs to others or exposition of the tenets of one's religion. But, it does not include a right to convert another person to one's own religion. Forcible conversions impinge on the 'freedom of conscience' guaranteed to all the persons alike.